

DOCUMENT 2

PARTNER RESEARCH, QUALIFICATION & CONTACT-FINDING GUIDE

Student Impact Challenge (S.I.C.) — Student Fellow Working Guide

YOUR JOB

Before sending outreach, determine whether an organization is a strong fit, identify the best partnership opportunity, and find the person most likely to make or influence the decision. Good research turns a cold email into a relevant partnership conversation.

Part 1 — Qualify the Organization Before Contacting It

Mission Alignment

Does the organization already care about youth, education, entrepreneurship, economic opportunity, innovation, community improvement, workforce development, financial literacy or families?

Audience Alignment

Can it reach students ages 10–20, parents, educators, businesses or community leaders?

Geographic Alignment

Does it operate in New York State, have a meaningful New York presence, or have a national program that could support New York youth?

Resource Alignment

Could it realistically provide awareness, scholarships, funding, prizes, products, experiences, venues, mentors, business access or media exposure?

Reputation & Safety

Is it an appropriate, credible organization to associate with a youth initiative?

Timing

Is there a current campaign, community program, grant cycle, event or initiative that creates a natural reason to contact them now?

Simple Qualification Score

Score	Meaning	Action
5 — Excellent	Strong mission, audience, geography and resource fit.	High-priority personalized outreach.
4 — Strong	Clear alignment with one or more meaningful partnership opportunities.	Contact this week.
3 — Possible	Some alignment but requires a stronger angle.	Research further before outreach.
1–2 — Weak	Little relevance or no clear value exchange.	Do not prioritize.

Part 2 — How to Research Each Prospect

1. Start With the Official Website

Read About, Community, Foundation, Social Impact, Corporate Responsibility, Newsroom, Partnerships, Sponsorships and Contact pages.

2. Search Recent News & Press Releases

Look for youth programs, scholarships, school partnerships, community grants, entrepreneurship programs, local events and charitable commitments.

3. Review LinkedIn

Search the organization plus titles such as Community Relations, Social Impact, Partnerships, Foundation, Corporate Affairs, Marketing or Market President.

4. Check Local Operations

For banks, hotels, gyms, dealerships, retailers and restaurants, determine whether a local/regional decision-maker may be more accessible than headquarters.

5. Identify One Personalization Point

Write down one specific reason this organization fits the challenge. This becomes the opening of the outreach message.

6. Determine the Best Ask

Choose awareness, scholarship, media, prize/experience, business access, community distribution or corporate sponsorship.

Part 3 — Find the Right Person

Organization	Titles / Departments to Search
Bank / Credit Union	Community Impact; Corporate Responsibility; Foundation; Community Development; Market President
Radio	Community Affairs; Promotions; Public Affairs; General Manager; Programming leadership
TV / Media	Community Affairs; Public Relations; Community/Assignment Desk; Partnerships
Sports Team	Community Relations; Team Foundation; Social Responsibility; Corporate Partnerships
Hotel	General Manager; Director of Sales & Marketing; Community Relations
Automotive	Corporate Social Impact; Foundation; Regional Marketing; local Dealer Principal/General Manager
Shoe / Apparel Brand	Social Impact; Community Impact; Brand Partnerships; Sports/Youth Marketing
Gym / Fitness	Community Relations; Regional Marketing; Franchise Owner; General Manager
Technology / Telecom	Education; Social Impact; Community Affairs; Corporate Responsibility
Retail / Supermarket	Community Relations; Regional Marketing; Corporate Affairs; local ownership
University	Community Engagement; Entrepreneurship Center; Student Affairs; Advancement; Outreach
Nonprofit / Community Group	Executive Director; Program Director; Youth Director; Partnerships; Community Outreach

Part 4 — Information to Record BEFORE Outreach

■ Organization name	■ Organization category
■ Website	■ New York/local presence
■ Contact person's full name	■ Exact job title
■ Public professional email/contact form	■ Public business phone
■ LinkedIn/profile source	■ Relevant community initiative found
■ Why the organization aligns	■ Recommended partnership type
■ Specific first ask	■ Qualification score (1–5)
■ Date research completed	■ Planned outreach date

Part 5 — What NOT to Do

- Do not guess email addresses and present them as verified.
- Do not use private personal contact information.
- Do not mass-email hundreds of organizations with identical language.
- Do not contact unrelated departments simply because an email is available.
- Do not claim an organization is a partner before it agrees.
- Do not promise logo placement, exclusivity, sponsorship benefits, media exposure or financial terms.
- Do not negotiate agreements. Escalate interested leads to program leadership.

Definition of a Research-Ready Lead

A lead is ready for outreach only when the fellow can answer: **Who are they? Why do they fit? Who should we contact? What have they already supported? What is the best first ask? What is our personalization point?**

Program Contact

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